Approaching Dusk: TTRPG Lore perspective

The birth of the twin divinities and the archipelago of Maca

The archipelago was a plain land before the birth of the twin divine rulers, Bathala and Bathrawarka. Their great powers are rooted from the pure energy of the archipelago, molded by the creation of complex life and desire—to live. These brothers were conceived by the magic and complexity of nature, allowing them to exist in the form of benevolence. These twins then created its first inhabitants, creating complex lifeforms similar to theirs and then they created more to make a paradise. Together, they created the archipelago that they first called as '**Maca**', meaning heaven but was also later dubbed as "*Talang nag sibol sa Mapiang Banwadagat*" and it was a magical archipelago where both mortals and divinities lived together for eras on end.

Despite being twins, their birth created a very different surge of divination, Bathala encompasses warmth—offering kindness and divine protection to everyone and everything. But his twin, Bathrawarka was born with wickedness and cunningness, encompassing the dichotomy of Bathala—darkness. Despite differing ideologies, they both wanted to be a benevolent ruler of the archipelago.

One day, Bathrawarka announced that he wanted to rule alone, and to keep his brother from 'pampering' their subjects. Offended, Bathala accepted his challenge. They decided to battle it out for full control—to which Bathala won. Seeing his brother bitter and heartbroken, he decided to compromise by dividing the rule between them. The light and the dark thus creating the cycle of day and night. However, Bathrawarka decided he wanted full control, without being the shadow of his brother. He devised a plan to engulf the world in eternal darkness, drawing powers from the world beyond this one, the **Kasanaan** or the equivalent of hell. His meddling with the universe's dark strongholds enraged Bathala and he threatened him to be imprisoned if he didn't stop. Bathala called upon the powers of the entire pantheon under his rule to definitely seal his own brother.

Behind the scenes, Bathrawarka had established his own main pantheon, the 7 moons, though he kept their existence hidden. He made them do his biddings sneakily, without alerting bathala or any of his pantheons.

Bathrawarka however, instead of mobilising his pantheon, he relied on blind obedience of mortals and divinities, doing his biddings for him—these subjects were the ones who felt the unfairness of the whole world , they agreed to the belief that "magical and mortals shouldn't live together because it establishes the unfair nature of being normal and powerful", ultimately, it became his greatest weapon because Bathala refused to do harm to his subjects, even if that means they didn't follow him anymore. Bathrawarka had been ordering his pantheon to gather the necessary ritual items and sacrificial necessities for his dark plan.

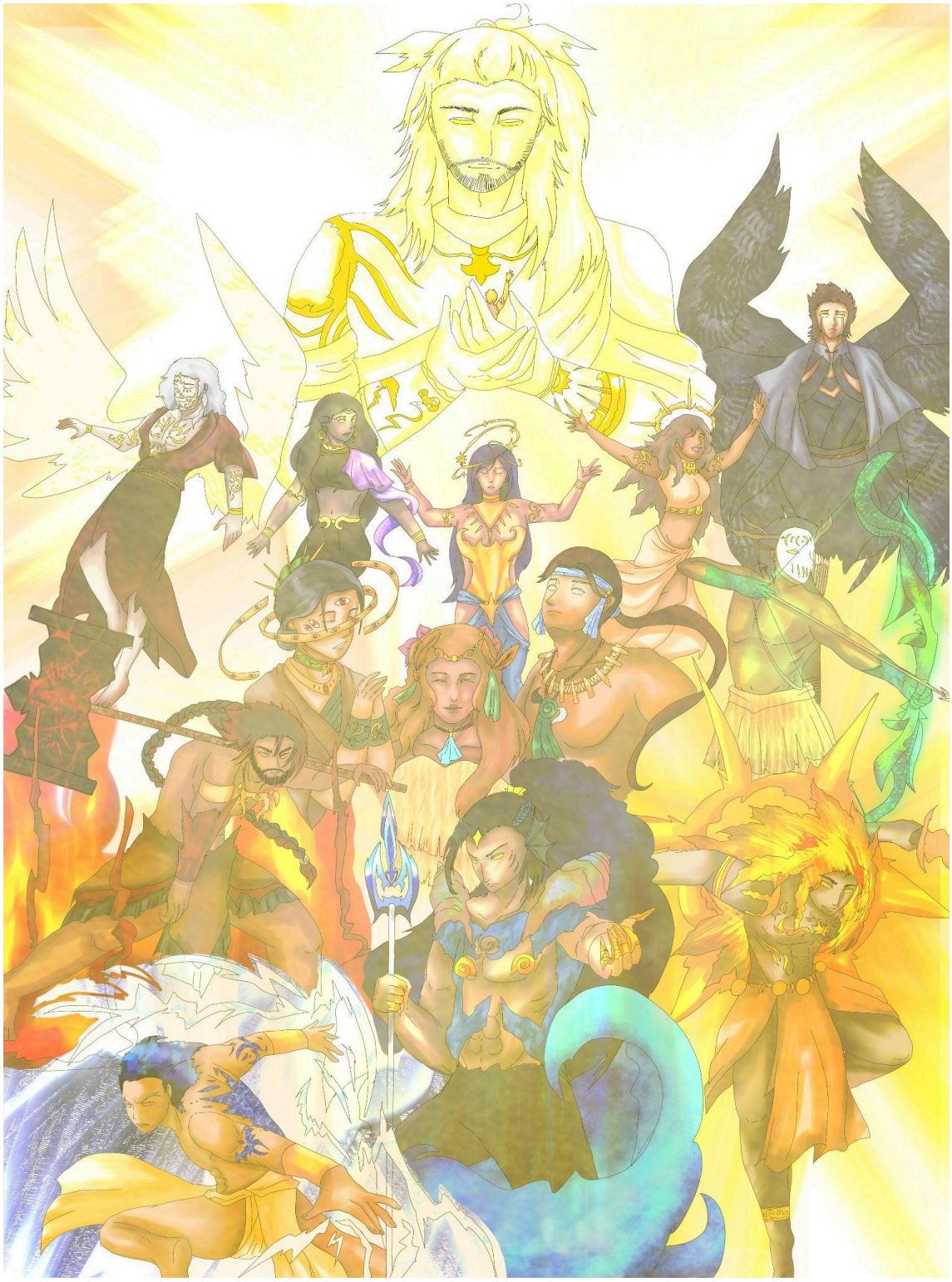
However, the rest of Bathala's pantheon urged him to do action, otherwise the archipelago would be thrown into chaos. His compassionate nature was exploited by his brother, the gradual fall of Bathala's rule cracked and shook the entire archipelago, this moment of weakness was seized by Bathrawarka and

he managed to perform his ritual, ultimately separating the dimension of mortality and divinity. But Bathala's last act was to stop this separation, sacrificing himself to secure and prevent anymore, but the large scope and great damage this ritual had done, Bathala had a hard time managing it so he asked for help with his pantheon. Together, they created the 3 major protectors hailing from Selurong, Mairete, and Ophir; these mighty protectors along with Bathala, managed to hold the world for centuries to come. This managed to balance out their divine prowess. Batahala gave up his powers to hold the world together while his twin was seeped out of his prowess from that large scale ritual. In a few more millennia, they were stagnant and unable to use their prowess.

The widescale ritual broke the archipelago of Maca, making some islands sink and more particularly, the region of Ophir was turned into a desert due to it being the heart of the dark ritual—the light and water was seeped out, leaving the region dry. Cracks and fissures riddled the archipelago throughout its entirety, reminding the people of divine wrath. To this day, these cracks became a hard reminder of such immense power from the forgotten gods.

Their inactivity made their subjects forget their existence, and eventually, the concept of deities slowly disappear…but was not entirely gone.

Pantheon Lineup for Bathala



Total: 13

Astral Council

- ☐ Mayari - Goddess of the night
- ☐ Hana - Goddess of the morning
- ☐ Tala - Goddess of the stars

The dichotomous voices of reason

- ☐ Makalun - messenger of the gods. They had wings. Their duty consisted in running errands for the superior deities of the skyworld and summoning other divinities to attend the various ceremonies performed by the priests of the village. He values life more than anything, he always reasons out to bathala that life should be allowed to live, not just survive. Existentialism.

- ☐ Imbagyan or Lingayan - messengers of death and guides of souls. One of the imbagyan was named himpugtan who had the power to terminate anything that displeased him or his favorites. He was the one to whom the people prayed to spare them from death; whom they invoked to end famine. He values the virtues and intricacies of anyone dead. He values the well being of a life even after they die. Nihilist.

Combatants

Marksman:

- ☐ Sugudun or Sugujun, the god of hunters and trappers.

Mage:

- ☐ Amanikabli, lord of the sea

Support:

- ☐ Idianali, goddess of labor and good deeds (body enhancement specialty)

Jungle/DPS:

- ☐ Kidlat - god of lightning,

Healer:

- ☐ Dalikamata- goddess of healing
- ☐ Akasi - god of health and sickness

Fighter/Tank:

- ☐ Apolaki- god of the sun and patron of fighters
- ☐ Gugurang - god of blacksmiths

Pantheon Lineup for Bathrawarka

Total: 12



The seven moons of Bathrawarka (combatants)

These are the seven moons based from the Visayan mythology regarding the Bakunawa. I modified the lore for this game. In this world, the moons were created by Bathrawarka instead of Bathala. These moons were created in order to throw balance and ensure chaos all across the archipelago. They fought against Bathala's pantheon but were ultimately devoured by Bakunawa in order to 'digest' and ultimately seal their prowess instead of just killing them.

1. **Bangkaw "Agani"**

   The eldest of the moons. He was the revered successor if Bathrawarka should fall. His main weapon is the spear, he wields it with great power and blinding energy.

2. **Dayang Luwalhati**

   Her presence escalates the rate of day and slows the night. Her presence at sea made the waves rowdy and disastrous.

3. **Desen Ker**

   His strong spirit to live and abide by Bathrawarka is unmatched. His mere aura is as dark as the deity himself. This overwhelming dark aura of his withered crops and animals due to its total darkness, it seeped all light.
   (desen = strength; manobo, ker = soul/spirit; maranao)

4. **Hiyas Gugma**

   Her incredible beauty taunts and makes those who look at her become obsessed to the point they'd do anything she wants—even betrayal and death.
   (hiyas = gem, palar = lucky; pangasinense)

5. **Bagwis Bendahara**

   He is the "Winged Collector". He was a god of contracts and gambling. If you can't pay what he asks in a contract, he would offer a chance to gamble. His contracts are absolute, he will oblige as long as the contractor is true and able to pay. But if you cross him, he will literally hunt you in his monstrous winged form.

   Bagwis means wing (used for birds, angels, or mythical creatures)
   Bendahara means Chief Treasurer or Vizier in visayan polities

6. **Raem Bikas**

   He is a mercenary. His services are bound to be done as long as you can pay the price, you can summon him through blood-related rituals. He only listens to Bathrawarka, he hates his other siblings.

   (raem = dignity from ilokano and bikas = briskness)

7. **Yugto Lawin** (he's the only one alive. He was sealed within the current moon that cycles in the current times)

    He was the youngest, his naivety and somewhat confused nature about Bathrawarka's desire made Bathala's Astral council to take pity on him and they actually pleaded to save him instead of allowing him to be devoured by the Bakunawa. He was taken care of by the Astral council yet the other pantheon of Bathala was wary of him because after all, he's still conjured by Bathrawarka, he could have some of his 'evil' within him.

    Lawin means "eagle" or "hawk" and is of Filipino origin, symbolizing strength and keen eyesight.

    Yugto means chapter. He's the last of the 7 moons, his endurance and fate was the last "chapter" of Bathrawarka's conquest, Yugto being sealed became a symbol to an end to the conquest.

Other Members of the Pantheon

- ☐ **Mangagauay**- She was the one responsible for the occurrence of diseases. She wore a necklace of skulls, and her girdle was made up of several severed human hairs and feet. Sometimes, she would change herself into a human being and roam about the countryside as a healer. She could induce maladies with her charms.
- ☐ **Be'tang** - shape shifting creatures residing in the forest ; they can also enter a person's sleep and terrorize their dreams and/or paralyse them.
- ☐ **Talagbusao** - a powerful and violent god of war.
- ☐ **Hukluban** - She had the power to change herself into any form she desired. In fact, some people said that she had greater power than Mangagauay. She could kill anyone by simply raising her hand. However, if she wanted to heal those whom she had made ill by her charms, she could do so without any difficulty. It was also said of her that she could destroy a house by merely saying that she would do so.
- ☐ **Gatui** - divinities of practical jokes. These deities correspond to the "harpies" of the Greeks. Unless given sumptuous offerings, they were said to feast on the souls of the villagers, especially those of the unborn. To a great extent, miscarriages among the Ifugao mothers were attributed to these deities.

Bathrawarka's Prominent Followers (BBEG)
Main/leaders of the Summoner Sect
Leader of this sect: Asuan

flies at night, murder men, eat their flesh, and drink their blood. He has four brothers.

All these five brothers were sent by the divinities to this world in the form of human beings, with special duties to do.

1. **Mangagayitma** specialized his charms; He made charms out of herbs, stones, and wood which, when :used by lovers, had the power to infuse the heart with love. Thus he deceived people, although sometimes, through the intercession of good anito, his skill would not work
2. **Sunat** was a well-known priest.
3. **Pangatahuyan** was a soothsayer (foresight).
4. **Bayuguin's** work was to tempt women into a life of shame.

Main/leaders of the Ritualist sect

1. **Mahipnat**, great spirits of sacred places. They dwelt in the downstream regions and were sometimes referred to as spirits of deified heroes.
2. **Hidit**, main prowess is conducting rituals. They are the ones who saw to it that proper punishments for those who broke taboos were meted out.
3. **Tulos-ka-balat**, spirit of sacrifices.

Mithi - Bathrawarka's Avatar

That's simply his name "Mithi" means "wish," "desire," or "aspiration.". His entire humanity and dedication was strongly with Bathrawarka and his alone. He greatly manifests the deity's mindset and mithi.

Classes

1. **Gahumagias (magicians)**

   Individuals who possessed a shred of magical prowess or '**Kalag**'. They could cast spells silently or via verbal incantations during battles depending on the spell's specifications. Gahumagias spends their time studying and perfecting spells throughout their time in magic classes and school. The modern Gahumagias were weaker compared to their predecessors due to the locked potential of their Kalags. Due to the dark sects persecution of magic and divine, the race of Gahumagias found ways to hide their magic prowess from the dark sects and their race eventually thinned and became scarce. Even the surviving families often had a skipped generation. Those who survive and manifest a strong Kalag were nurtured and taught in the Magic Capital of the archipelago, **Hikmarúm**.

   For modern Gahumagias, some of their powers and Kalags were locked due to the years of hiding. For them to unlock it, they must be able to awaken their Kalags through literally unleashing their kalags constantly until it breaks the physical limitation of the user. Once the body broke, the unleashed Kalag would restore and heal what's broken and reconstruct it in a way that

adapts to the user's main type of magic. The 'awakening' is often violent, resulting in scars but their Kalags find ways to make it beautiful (creating patterns, making the scar colored like their magic ex. If the user's power is water, the Kalag would make the scar blue).

Essentially making the scars as their own unique tattoos, in nod to the 'Pintados'

Type	Modification after awakening	Indigenous View
White / Healing Magic	Hands would glow every time the user cast magic.	Invoking *anito* or *diwata* for protection, rain, fertility, or healing.
Black / Harmful Magic	There would be a creeping black discoloration on the fingertips, the more the user cast, the more the darkness would consume them.	Sorcery (*kulam*, *barang*) used for vengeance, jealousy, or social control.
Sympathetic Magic	There would be a carved crest on the users' forehead and chest, signifying their understanding and sympathy every time they cast magic.	Using representations (dolls, effigies, insects) to affect a person spiritually.
Divinatory Magic	Their eyes would glow faintly or brightly depending on the power they exert in casting.	Reading omens, dreams, or nature to gain insight from spirits.
Transformative Magic	Their limbs would be turned temporarily to the kind of material that they are transforming. (ex. If they're using wood, their limbs would shortly become wooden too. Will wear off after the casting.)	Shifting or enhancing one's *dungan* to gain strength, beauty, or invulnerability (as in warriors' *anting-anting*).

Kinds	Description
Incantation	The spell must be said out loud in order for it to activate and take effect
Ritualistic/Ceremonial	Power flows through symbolic materials used during rites. There are certain required materials in casting, the whole ritual would not start/finish if there's something missing.
Consecration	What is blessed, becomes sacred.
Contagion	What touches, connects. Example: hair, clothing, or footprints could be used to affect the person they belonged to
Sacrificial	The performer of this must pay a price first, often personal like blood, a limb in order to perform the spell

2. **Animatos (fighter)**

Much like Gahumagias, the Animatos are prosecuted and are now scarce. Animatos are the half-blood, an offspring of a mortal and divine being. They possess godly strength or 'Basbas' inherited from their godly/divine parent. However, these Animatos do not get their powers as easily as just being born, they had to pass a series of trials made by their anitos and by the council of the 'Dalaketnon'. These Dalaketnon would organize the trials for the aspiring Animatos, making sure that each trial is tailored for a specific person (there's no real standard for these tests) and they are mostly measuring the Animato's personal, mental, and physical strength, they are also the judge who will decide if they are even worthy to take the tests or if they pass.

3. **Babaylans (druid, healers)**

Babaylans' powers are often harvested and perfected from nature, relying on natural environments, hurdles, and experiences to train and master their crafts. Their initial role was to protect their respective tribal lands but they could also act as healers.

However, there are two sides from the same coin, much like the babaylans, they also have some other dark distinction:

- Their prowess relies on which side their tribes worship. Some tribes are in favor of Bathala, some are with Bathrawarka.

- Those who sides with Bathala can:
  - Heal people fully, even severed limbs and persistent diseases
  - Can do either white magic, divinatory, sympathetic, and transformative (though this is the hardest to learn among all others)

- Those who sides with Bathrawarka can:
  - Do either black magic, divinatory, ritualistic magics (necromancy), and transformative (mostly for disguises and trickery)
  - Unique: summon dark forces (although they disguise them as harmless animals/creatures through the use of transformative magics.)

- Note: Babaylans can only use one type of magic throughout, that's their main distinction from Gahumagias because Gahumagias can cast all types of magic.
- Both can try to do ritualistic magic, though their purposes vary.
- Nobody can tell the difference (outsiders) between the tribe's distinction (who they worship, they make sure to keep it secret).
- Modern babaylans focus on helping their tribe, they rarely leave their tribe unless absolutely necessary.
- There's still rivalry between the light and dark sides, if two babaylans from different factions meet, they often can tell that they're from the opposing side, they just can't prove it. It's always a 'I can just tell' without any evidence.

4. **Katalonan (paladins)**

They are the holy warriors hailing from Hanunoo. Their original occupation when not in combat is priest/priestess. They were the last remaining religious branch that worships Bathala and his pantheons. They extremely detest the faction of Bathrawarka and were determined to expel and exterminate his forces hence why they were also trained as warriors. As priest/priestess, they protect the holy information and relics left behind by Bathala and his pantheons, it is crucial for them to keep the memory and history of Bathala alive. They rarely fight unless it's against the dark sect, but as long as their allies believe in Bathala, they will continue to aid them without question.

There is a hierarchy within the Katalonans:

a. **Abiyan** - This is the one considered as the deity's avatar. Abiyans are originally animatos, usually those who exceeded the Animatos trials, to which they received the highest basbas from their divine parents and were chosen to become their avatar instead. Though these cases are rare, if there's a certified Abiyan, the Katalonans and Paratabog treat them with utmost respect and reverence.

b. **Katalonans** - The high priest or priestess, main leaders. Possesses the highest spiritual and physical prowess.

c. **Paratabog** - these are the main combatants, often having immense physical strength and spiritual prowess but they could be further distinguished:
   i. **Parayen** - for expeditions and quests outside the Hanunoo, their main distinction is that they are chanters, often casting offensive and defensive spells through songs and verbal incantations.
   ii. **Paratambal** - mainly for siege and guarding. They provide security because of their strength, they could drive enemies away though they are also well-versed with healing.

5. **Pajareador (Marksman)**

Hailing from the Sanghaya forest, the Pajareador are good with using range weapons like bows, throwing spears/knives, blowguns and slings. If their ammos run out, they'd just bring another set of weapons with its own set of ammos. Their sharp marksman skills were honed from the heavy rainforest, often having a keen sense of animals hiding and camouflaging. They are also expert poisoners, concocting potent poisons from various plants and other means like snake venom.

Pre-made Characters' Lore

Kael Sadiri - Gahumagia "from the word kahel and sadiri an ilocano word for intelligent"



His family's name was Sadiri, his name Kael came from the day he was born—a bright, warm orange sky greets the day as his cries first echoed as he was cradled in his mother's arms. However, this premonition of a remarkable child being born suddenly became a curse because his mother knew—that her child is a Gahumagia. His strong Kalag is warm, warmer than the sun itself. The array of orange skies confirms her suspicions, the gods gave another gahumagia…In his early years, Kael showed no signs of being a Gahumagia, it seems that his powers were kept locked as intended but by the time he reached 12, his powers slightly shows and it gives fear in the heart of his mother, Dalisay. In their hometown in Wararka, gahumagias are typically trained as warriors, serving for the monarchy until they die. Rumors have it that once a

gahumagias swore an oath to the king, they'd be used and disposed of like rusted weapons. She can't let that happen. Dalisay packed minimal, like she's just going for a short trip to avoid suspicions. She urged Kael to pack too and said that they're just going out for a trip. The trip itself is treacherous, her frail body can be felt like it's giving up yet she can't quit, she can't handle another loss of a loved one and not be able to do something about it. Her husband, Kalis, was also a gahumagia but upon exhausting his power, he was 'killed in action' as per the report of the king's guards. She travelled all the way to Lunob Awan, seeking sanctuary. When they reached the sanctuary, Kael was filled with questions as to why, upon being safe, Dalisay told him why. Kael was furious and wanted to really know what happened to his father but his mother was hesitant, she said that Kael's power is still too weak to even try and combat the Wararka royal family.

As Kael grew up, he knew he had powers but even he himself can't control and unlock its true potential. His mother then suggested for him to pursue his curiosity and unlock his capabilities, there is a region who teaches gahumagias like him—a school in Hikmarum, the magic capital of the north archipelago.

Haliya Sugbu - Animato "masked moon goddess" in Visayan mythology and sugbu "to wade into the water" or "to dive into water," stemming from a Proto-Philippine word (sug(e)bu), or it can refer to "scorched earth" or "great fire". (girl)



Haliya was born in Shivi-al. From birth, she was one with the warriors. For a while, her strength seems normal for a typical Shiv but when she started 'commanding' the seas and taming the flames made the entire settlement of the Shiv to question her 'natural strength'. Their elder instructed her to go on a perilous journey north, just beyond the thunderous clouds of Taika Oblak. The elder was strict with the timeline, she had to arrive within a week—precisely, otherwise her journey is useless. In reality, the elder was trying to make her go to the Didicas islands while it was still visible, if she missed her deadline, the didicas islands would soon submerge and won't show itself for an indefinite amount of time. On her journey to the far north, she was accompanied by anitos, helping or playing tricks around her.

Despite the various nuisances, she managed to reach the far north, and was instructed to manifest and control the waters as she sailed. To which she barely managed to tame. She arrived shortly at Didicas islands by the sixth day. The anitos revealed that she was an ‘animato’ and the final test by the council of the Dalaketnon is to be held shortly. After completing the trial, she went home proudly, waiting to announce her ‘passed’ status and her heritage—she was ready to share the tale but what greeted her was the ravaged village of her settlement. The surrounding area was literal scorched earth and there were traces of the ritual abomination of monsters.

Sulà - Babaylan



He was the babaylan of the Batuk-an Patik, his years of service honed his healing and divination magic skills to its utmost precision and mastery. However, there have been several environmental problems recently: earthquakes, storm surges, and the slow and gradual decay of crops from their neighbouring forests. Being their tribe’s babaylan, he was asked to do some kind of clairvoyant magic in hopes of finding answers why they are experiencing these disasters. During his ritual, he used his divination magic, searching for answers from anitos and nature alike. What he saw was so devastating; he can't even say it to the tribe. He just said
“We…I have to do something…”

A few days later, he prepared many protective spells and blessed many relics and talismans to keep his tribe safe while he prepared for a journey. His goal was to reach Kayo Punlaan or the “Sacred Tree” in hopes to find more and deeper insight from it. But his suspicions were just confirmed by the sacred tree…The end is beginning, a certain group of people are making the gears of the nefarious plan to turn. He has to do something about it.

Salaknib - Katalonan (salaknib is an Ilocano word for "shield")



The impact of the dark plan was felt even by the Katalonans in Hanunoo. Salaknib was one of the high priests and the tremors of the quakes, the imbalance between the climates and decay of nature is becoming more and more apparent. His suspicion is that the followers of bathrawarka are behind it so he decided to conduct an experiment. He compared the length of day and night. If the world is balanced, there should be an equal amount of it because that's how Bathala left the world—in proper balance. When he conducted it, the night was longer by an hour, it confirmed his suspicions and fear. He mobilized his faction, to sleuth and be more alert. He knew something was wrong, but thinking where to actually start looking for answers is a problem.

Talao - Pajareador (guy)



A hunter in Sanghaya forest. During his recent hunts, he noticed that some plants are in the state of decay or near decay. He knew that something was wrong but he couldn't pinpoint it. Upon returning from one of his hunts, he reported his findings to their settlement leader. The elders were shaken from this news, they feared that the 'balance' was being tainted. They instructed Talao to keep a look out for suspicious people wandering in their lands as well as those sleuthing around Sanghaya and Mt. Pulag.

Writing and Spoken Language in this TTRPG

For this TTRPG, this is how the writing script works:

Baybayin: mainly used by coastal, and sea-faring people. Inspired by how the waves work.

Syllable-based, written from left to right horizontally, mimicking the literal sea horizon. Baybayin is the de facto script, however, there are regional influences and creation of another script.

- **Hamunoo:** mainly used by mainland/in-landers. Main inspiration is baybayin but also created specific characters for this variation.
    - written left-to-right but with a vertical orientation, mimicking the orientation of the trees.

- The baybayin and Hamunoo scripts act like common writing scripts, widescale use and everyone can read and write it. Despite the varying language and dialects across the archipelago, most people can translate it to baybayin/Hamunoo-based scripts—a shared written system that transcends dialectal differences.